

TRIGGER: Theology Lounge — does “prayers” in 1 Tim 2 include imprecations against rulers?

TEXT: BTE NKJV · usmcmmin.org · Lexicon + MOOP Dictionary

ISSUE. May (or must) Christians pray *imprecatory* prayers — asking God to judge, restrain, remove, or break wicked governmental leaders — or does 1 Timothy 2:1–4 lock prayer for rulers into blessing, salvation, and quiet civil peace only?

DEFINITION. *Imprecation* = Godward appeal against evil persons/powers (judgment, frustration of schemes, removal from office; extreme OT forms include death). Not private revenge; not fleshly venting with a “Dear Lord” prefix.

1 · 1 TIMOTHY 2 — THE TAXONOMY OF PRAYER

Greek · BTE

1 Tim 2:1–2	“I exhort first of all that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks be made for all men, for kings and all who are in authority, that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and reverence.” (BTE NKJV)
Purpose	ἵνα (hina) purpose clause: quiet/peaceable life + godliness — not “so that Caesar falls.” Coupled to v.3–4: God “desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.”
1 Tim 2:8	Men pray “lifting up holy hands, without wrath and doubting .” Rage-imprecation fails the verse before it leaves the mouth.

δέησις · *deësis* · G1162 · Supplication

Urgent request from felt need; “to be in want, to beg.” More pointed than general prayer. Paul pairs it with proseuchē. usmcmmin.org/lexicon/G1162

προσευχή · *proseuchē* · G4335 · Prayer

Directed prayer to God — communion, not mere shopping list. Place of prayer in Acts 16:13. Core discipline. usmcmmin.org/lexicon/G4335

ἐντεύξις · *enteuxis* · G1783 · Intercession

Approach a king with a petition; audience with the sovereign on behalf of another. Christlike gap-standing (Rom 8:34; Heb 7:25). Broad enough for “save him” and “thwart this decree.” usmcmmin.org/lexicon/G1783

εὐχαριστία · *eucharistia* · G2169 · Thanksgiving

“Good grace” — gratitude as posture. In 1 Tim 2 it sits beside intercession: you thank God for rulers even while you petition against their evil. usmcmmin.org/lexicon/G2169

2 · MOOP DICTIONARY — RECLAIMED WORDS

usmcmmin.org/dictionary

Prayer	“Divinely appointed means by which the creature communes with the Creator — not merely petitioning for things, but entering relational presence... adoration, confession, thanksgiving, and supplication.” Psalms = raw prayer book. /dictionary/prayer
Intercession	“Prayer offered on behalf of another, standing in the gap... fundamentally a priestly act.” Christ always lives to intercede (Heb 7:25). Abraham for Sodom; Moses after the calf; Ezek 22:30 gap-stander. /dictionary/intercession
Vengeance	“Righteous execution of justice against evil — specifically as a divine prerogative... Personal vengeance forbidden (Rom 12:19); institutional vengeance to governing authorities (Rom 13:4); cosmic vengeance God’s alone. Saints’ cry in Rev 6:10 is longing for justice, not pettiness.” /dictionary/vengeance
Curse	“Divinely authorized pronouncement of separation, judgment, and forfeit — opposite of blessing... covenant reality... Christ became a curse for us (Gal 3:13).” Not superstition; not casual malediction. /dictionary/curse

3 · CONTROLLING CANON — EXPANDED

BTE NKJV

Matt 5:43–45	“Love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you, that you may be sons of your Father... He makes His sun rise on the evil and on the good.”
Rom 12:9, 14, 19–21	“Abhor what is evil. Cling to what is good... Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse... do not avenge yourselves... ‘Vengeance is Mine, I will repay,’ says the Lord... overcome evil with good.”
Rom 13:1–4	Authority “appointed by God... God’s minister... does not bear the sword in vain... an avenger to execute wrath on him who practices evil.” Civil sword ordained; private sword banned.
Acts 4:24–30	Church under threat prays Ps 2 (“kings of the earth set themselves... against the LORD and His Anointed”), then asks not for Herod’s death but for boldness and healings while God does “whatever Your hand and Your purpose determined.”
Acts 4:19; 5:29	“We ought to obey God rather than men” — civil disobedience when commanded to sin; not a blank check for curse-prayers.
2 Thess 1:6–8	“It is a righteous thing with God to repay with tribulation those who trouble you... when the Lord Jesus is revealed... in flaming fire taking vengeance on those who do not know God.”
Ps 2:1–4	“Why do the nations rage... The kings of the earth set themselves... Against the LORD and against His Anointed... He who sits in the heavens shall laugh.”
Ps 109:6–8	“Set a wicked man over him... When he is judged, let him be found guilty... Let his days be few, and let another take his office.” (Applied to Judas, Acts 1:20.)
Ps 139:19–24	“Oh, that You would slay the wicked, O God!... Do I not hate them, O LORD, who hate You?... I hate them with perfect hatred...” → immediately: “Search me, O God... see if there is any wicked way in me.”
Rev 6:10	Martyrs: “How long, O Lord, holy and true, until You judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?” Heaven times the cry; does not scold it.
Heb. qalal · H7043	לָלַל — to make light, treat as worthless, curse. Opposite of כָּבֵד kabad (heavy/honor). To curse is to declare someone weightless. /lexicon/H7043



BTE · 1 TIM 2

usmcmmin.org/bible.html?ref=1+Timothy+2

LEX · ENTEUXIS G1783

usmcmmin.org/lexicon/G1783.html

DICT · PRAYER

usmcmmin.org/dictionary/prayer.html

DICT · VENGEANCE

usmcmmin.org/dictionary/vengeance.html

BTE · PSALM 109

usmcmmin.org/bible.html?ref=Psalm+109

HOLD: 1 Tim 2 = standing order · Imprecation = exceptional magazine · No partisan lighter fluid

SCAN: QR → live BTE / lexicon / dictionary

4 · CASE AGAINST IMPRECATING GOVERNMENTAL LEADERS

restrain

ARGUMENTS

- **1 Tim 2** purpose clause is quiet godliness + salvation — not the ruin of Caesar as aim.
- Written in **Nero's** world. Pastorals model thanksgiving/intercession, not psalm-curses as default.
- **Matt 5 / Rom 12**: bless, do not curse; leave vengeance to God.
- **1 Tim 2:8** bans wrath-fueled prayer. Most chat “imprecations” are party spirit baptized.
- Christians are not OT theocratic magistrates. Davidic royal lawsuits ≠ cable-news liturgy.
- **Acts 4** under threat: quote Ps 2, ask boldness — not “kill Herod.”
- Gospel often advanced *through* unjust courts. Open doors > body counts.
- Dictionary *curse*: covenant judgment language — not casual malediction toward opponents.

PASTORAL RISK

- Confuses prophetic lament with political revenge fantasy.
 - Trains men to hate opponents harder than their own sin (fails Ps 139:23–24).
 - Public imprecation without truth/due process = slander with amen.
 - Witness dies: world hears bloodlust, not the cross.
 - Selective: imprecate *their* tyrants; excuse *ours*.
 - Skips enemy-love while quoting judgment psalms.
- Strong AGAINST:** NT forbids person-directed imprecation; only blessing + lawful justice appeal.

5 · CASE FOR IMPRECATION (RIGHTLY ORDERED)

advance

ARGUMENTS

- Imprecatory psalms are **inspired** (2 Tim 3:16), Israel's worship book — not errata.
- **Ps 109:8 → Acts 1:20**: apostolic use of “let another take his office.”
- **Rev 6:10**: martyrs cry for avenging blood; heaven schedules, does not silence.
- **Rom 12:9** “Abhor what is evil” sits beside “bless persecutors.” Feed an enemy; still ask God to smash his trafficking.
- *enteuxis* = petition before a king — can include “convert,” “restrain,” “remove.”
- Quiet/peaceable life may *require* God to break a ruler's violence (Pharaoh, Haman, Herod patterns).
- Rom 13 “minister” who becomes terror to good is malfunctioning; saints appeal higher (Acts 5:29).
- **2 Thess 1:6–8**: divine repayment on troublemakers is “righteous.”
- Dictionary *vengeance*: personal banned; cosmic God's; cry for justice can be holy.

GUARDRAILS IF FOR

- **Target:** hardened evil / oppression of image-bearers — not election disappointment.
 - **Aim:** God's glory, weak protected, gospel free — not tribe win.
 - **Order:** salvation desire first; judgment if they will not turn (Ezek 33).
 - **Mode:** ask *God*; refuse private vengeance, doxxing, stochastic violence.
 - **Self-exam:** Ps 139:23–24 before 139:21–22.
 - **Office vs person:** “another take his office” cleaner than cursing children (handle Ps 109's harshest lines with Christ/final judgment care — not memes).
 - **Without wrath:** 1 Tim 2:8 still binds. Hot anger ≠ holy zeal.
 - **Consistency:** same standard for “our” leaders as “theirs.”
- Strong FOR:** Legitimate NT-era appeal when evil is clear, vengeance renounced, love still seeks conversion.

6 · SYNTHESIS — USMC WORKING POSITION

command brief

Neither “imprecate every official you dislike” nor “only soft prayers forever.”

- 1 Tim 2:1–4 = standing order:** thanks, intercession, desire for rulers' salvation, conditions for the church's godly peace.
- Imprecation = **exceptional magazine** — clear, grave, unrepentant evil destroying the image of God (bloodshed, predatory law, persecution, crushing the weak).
- When used: Godward · justice-shaped · repentance-open · vengeance-renouncing · self-examined · non-partisan in standard.
- Layer petitions: (a) convert → (b) restrain → (c) remove from power → (d) final judgment if hardened — don't leap to (d).
- Corporate public prayer defaults to 1 Tim 2 tone; sharper judicial language belongs in sober lament, not rage entertainment.
- Greek taxonomy helps the Lounge: *deēsis* / *proseuchē* / *enteuxis* / *eucharistia* are not synonyms for “be nice.” *enteuxis* is a throne-room brief — still under holy hands without wrath.

“Pray for kings” and “How long, O Lord?” are not enemies. One is the church's daily posture under empire. The other is the church's cry when empire drinks blood. Wisdom is knowing which hour it is — and whether your heart is clean enough to tell the difference.

7 · FIELD ORDERS — REAL MAN PRAYER

IOS

DO

- Name leaders by office; thank God for common grace.
- Ask wisdom, justice, protection of unborn/weak, free gospel.
- Ask God to frustrate wicked decrees and expose corruption.
- Ask repentance unto life for hostile rulers.
- Confess your wrath (1 Tim 2:8) before hard petitions.
- Scan BTE / lexicon; pray with open Bible, not open rage-feed.

DO NOT

- Baptize revenge or party hatred as “discernment.”
- Pray death casually over opponents.
- Skip enemy-love while quoting judgment psalms.
- Confuse prophetic boldness with online cruelty.
- Ignore Rom 13 lawful order while demanding heaven's sword.
- Imprecate “them” with a standard you won't apply to “us.”



BTE · MATT 5

bible.html?ref=Matthew+5



BTE · ROM 12-13

bible.html?ref=Romans+12



BTE · PSALM 139

bible.html?ref=Psalm+139



DICT · INTERCESSION

dictionary/intercession.html



DICT · CURSE

dictionary/curse.html



LEX · DEESIS G1162

lexicon/G1162.html

WATCH CHARGE: Hold 1 Timothy 2 as your daily bearing toward every authority God has allowed — and keep the imprecatory psalms as holy fire for true tyranny, never as lighter fluid for your flesh. Love enemies. Abhor evil. Leave vengeance to the Judge. Plead for quiet godliness and open truth. If you must ask God to break a ruler, first ask Him to break you.